BUSINESS PLAN SUMMARY

Apps for Change

Free Apps. Real Change. Community-Powered.

Prepared for funders by Sam, Executive Director · Version 3, updated October 28, 2026

At a glance

Apps for Change builds free, never-monetized well-being apps for everyday people, and is seeking about $4,500 to bring four of them to public launch in 2027.

- **Who we are:** a Minnesota nonprofit corporation founded in [year] (EIN [EIN]), tax-exempt under Section 501(c)(3), led by founder and Executive Director Sam.
- **What we build:** four free apps for iOS and Android: Advocate's Compass, Goal Getter, Care About You, and Beat the Craving.
- **Our promise:** no subscriptions, no advertising, no in-app purchases, and no data sales. Our nonprofit structure removes any incentive to monetize users.
- **Where we are:** all four apps are in beta. Public launches roll out across 2027, starting with Advocate's Compass.
- **Targets:** 1,000 downloads (stretch: 2,500) and 2 formal partner organizations in 2027, growing to 5,000 downloads and 500 monthly active users across each app's first year after launch.
- **The ask:** about $4,500 in grants, gifts, and in-kind support for 2027. A lean floor plan of about $2,000 still ships all four apps.

The need

Many Minnesotans need practical, everyday support between appointments, and the apps that could help often come with a catch.

- **Speaking up in disability services.** More than 74,000 Minnesotans used the state's four disability waivers in 2024, each with recurring planning meetings about their services. Minnesota is also redesigning these waivers to add individual budgets and more self-direction, which means more decisions for people and families to make. (Minnesota House Research, 2025)
- **Staying in recovery.** About 876,000 Minnesotans age 12 and older (18.1%) had a substance use disorder in 2022 to 2023, above the national rate of 17.2% (KFF, from SAMHSA data). In 2025, 983 Minnesotans died of a drug overdose, nearly three every day (Minnesota Department of Health).
- **Staying connected.** In mid-2025, 21% of U.S. adults said they felt lonely a lot of the previous day, the highest rate since 2021. Among adults 30 to 44, it was 25%. (Gallup, 2025)
- **Tools with a catch.** Many well-being apps lock features behind subscriptions or are funded by advertising and user data. That model works against the people who most need help.

Our approach

We compete on trust: our apps are free, private, and shaped by the people who use them, and our nonprofit form keeps them that way.

- **Free, with no catch.** With no owners or shareholders, nothing pulls us toward paywalls, upsells, or ads. Crisis resources are never paywalled.
- **Privacy-first.** Data is stored securely in the cloud, never sold, never used for advertising, and never shared with partners or funders. Users can delete it at any time.
- **AI only on request.** Where an app offers AI help, it runs only when the user asks for it.
- **Community-powered.** Users help set the roadmap through virtual town halls written into our bylaws, plus focus groups and private testing before each launch.
- **Built with lived experience.** People in recovery, self-advocates, and families test and shape each app before it reaches the public.
- **Accessible from the start.** Each app is designed for screen readers, large text, and plain language, and reviewed with disabled users before public launch.

Programs

Each app runs as its own program, with its own audience, outcomes, and measures, and all four reach public launch in 2027.

App	What it does	Who it serves	Public launch target
Advocate's Compass	Self-advocacy lessons, plain-language scripts for real conversations (generated on request), and a meeting tracker for prep, notes, and follow-ups	People with disabilities and families navigating waiver services, and anyone who needs to speak up for themselves	April 2027
Goal Getter	Turns goals across twelve life areas into action steps and milestones, with a progress dashboard	Millennial adults working on personal, career, and financial goals	Mid-September 2027
Care About You	Plans acts of kindness for others and for yourself, and puts each one on your calendar	Millennial adults who want to feel more connected	By November 13, 2027 (World Kindness Day)
Beat the Craving	Builds a personal set of coping strategies, with days-in-recovery and cravings-beaten counters, trigger notes that reveal patterns, and a button to call or find AA. Fully manual, with no AI	Adults in early recovery from alcohol, nicotine, or other drugs, on any recovery path	Early December 2027

> Beat the Craving complements treatment and peer support. It is not a treatment program and makes no clinical claims.

Community town halls

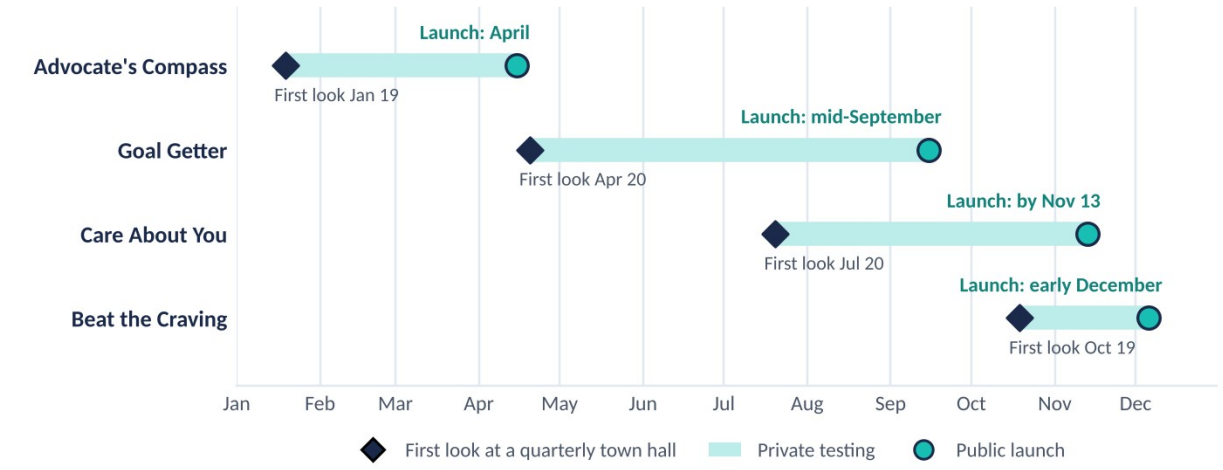
Starting January 19, 2027, a quarterly virtual town hall gives the community a first look at each new app before it launches.

- **Written into our bylaws.** Article VI, Section 6.8 makes town halls part of governance: what people share is summarized and presented to the Board.
- **One first look per quarter.** Each 45-minute session previews one app, shows what changed because of user ideas, and invites 12 to 20 adults to test it privately before launch.
- **Your ideas, answered.** Attendees bring ideas for new features and new apps. Every idea is logged, scored, reported to the Board, and answered within two weeks.
- **Open to everyone.** Sessions have live captions, phone dial-in, and accommodations on request, and are never recorded.
- **2027 goal:** 10 or more attendees per town hall, and at least three changes per app that came from community feedback.

2027 goals and milestones

Each app debuts at a quarterly town hall, goes through private testing, and then launches publicly, so all four are live by December 2027.

Each app gets a first look, private testing, then a public launch: all four live by December 2027



- **Downloads:** 1,000 across the live apps by December 2027 (stretch: 2,500)
- **Website and online giving:** redesigned appsforchange.org, by January 2027
- **Co-design and access:** four focus groups (one per app) and an accessibility review of each app before launch
- **Partners:** two formal partners, one recovery organization and one disability advocacy organization
- **East Metro pilot:** an Advocate's Compass pilot with East Metro partners, with at least half of participants living in Dakota, Ramsey, or Washington County. Timing and size will be set with East Metro partners and funders in early 2027.

Measuring impact

Each program tracks one core outcome and a reach target for its first year after launch; together, the four apps target 5,000 downloads and 500 monthly active users.

Program	Outcome we work toward	Key first-year measure	First-year reach
Advocate's Compass	People walk into meetings prepared and voice their own priorities	75% of users rate their latest meeting 4 or 5 for feeling prepared, in their own meeting notes	1,500 downloads, 150 monthly users
Goal Getter	Goals turned into action and achieved	50% of active users complete a milestone within 90 days	1,000 downloads, 100 monthly users
Care About You	More kindness, less loneliness	50% of Impact Panel members who start out lonely improve on the UCLA 3-Item Loneliness Scale	1,000 downloads, 100 monthly users
Beat the Craving	More cravings managed without a return to use	70% of logged cravings marked as managed without use	1,500 downloads, 150 monthly users

Counted, not asked. Usage outcomes come from app data and are counted automatically as totals. Nothing inside the apps asks survey questions. Advocate's Compass users can rate each meeting in their own notes, and nothing prompts them to.

The AFC Impact Panel. Well-being and other self-reported outcomes come from adults who choose to join our Impact Panel through a link in each app's Settings or on our website. Members answer a short email survey when they join and again at 3 and 12 months, using validated scales such as the WHO-5 Well-Being Index and BARC-10. In return, they get their own well-being snapshot, first access to new apps, early results, and, if they want it, recognition in our impact report.

Reported with care. We report only totals and never show results for groups smaller than 10. Panel members, town hall guests, and workshop participants can share their county of residence, so we can report to community foundations by the areas they serve. Starting in 2028, an annual impact report goes to users, funders, and our Board, and we plan a formal evaluation with a Minnesota university or independent partner by 2029.

Marketing and outreach

Our 2027 marketing plan prioritizes app users, then partners, then donors, on a $500 budget and three to five hours a week, starting in Minnesota and reaching everyone else online.

- **Free reach before paid.** We are applying for Google Ad Grants, up to $10,000 a month in free search ads, and pairing it with op-eds, LinkedIn posts, and helpful answers in local online groups, all drawing on our Executive Director's years in Minnesota human services.
- **One destination.** Every channel invites people to the next quarterly town hall and to our quarterly newsletter, where newcomers become users, testers, and supporters.
- **Partners who already serve our users.** Outreach starts with disability and self-advocacy organizations for Advocate's Compass, then coaches, volunteer centers, and recovery organizations for the apps that follow. Beat the Craving is promoted only through partners and organic channels.

- **Many small donors.** Asks stay light until the November giving days and a year-end appeal, with a $10 monthly giving option all year. A broad donor base also helps us meet the IRS public support test.
- **Careful, accessible messaging.** We check every claim against our privacy policy, make no health claims, name partners only once they agree in writing, and provide captions, alt text, and large print.
- **2027 targets:** 1,000 downloads (stretch: 2,500), 300 newsletter subscribers, 40 donors, 3 partners sharing our apps, 2 published op-eds, and 1,000 website visits a month by late 2027.

Leadership and governance

A three-member Board governs AFC, and the organization's governance documents are already written.

- **Sam, Founder, Executive Director, and Board Chair.** Brings director-level and frontline experience in Minnesota disability waiver programs (CADI, BI, DD, and Housing Support) and a B.A. in Individualized Studies from Metropolitan State University.
- **Joe, Chief Change Engineer and Board Secretary.** Directs engineering and data work professionally, and builds the apps with Sam.
- **Lynn, Chief People Officer and Treasurer.** Oversees financial records, controls, and IRS filings, and reports at each regular Board meeting.
- **Governance documents.** Bylaws and conflict-of-interest, whistleblower, and document-retention policies aligned with Minnesota Statutes Chapter 317A, plus a Privacy Policy and Terms of Service. A Board roster is available on request.
- **Capacity.** We run lean: the Executive Director gives about 10 hours a week and the Lead Developer about 10 hours a month, supported by Google for Nonprofits.
- **Tax status.** AFC is tax-exempt under Section 501(c)(3). By December 1, 2026, we will file IRS Form 8940 to update our classification to a public charity, matching how AFC operates.

Financial plan

Our 2027 plan is deliberately lean: $4,235 in planned spending, with a $1,719 floor that still ships all four apps.

Use of funds, 2027	Target	Floor
Legal review (governance, Terms of Service, privacy)	$500	$250
Insurance (directors and officers, general liability)	$1,000	$500
Accounting and bookkeeping	$1,000	$500
Focus groups and community research	$600	$200
Marketing and outreach	$500	$100
Website and hosting	$250	$13
Contingency (10%)	$385	$156
Total	**$4,235**	**$1,719**

Planned support of $4,500 (floor: $2,000) comes from foundation grants, individual gifts, corporate and matching gifts, and in-kind help, so both scenarios end the year with a small surplus. The plan includes no salaries or paid development.

Beyond 2027, we will grow a broad base of individual donors alongside foundation support. Any future earned revenue, such as licensing curriculum to other organizations, would need Board approval and would never charge app users.

Looking ahead

We start in Minnesota, but our apps are free to anyone, anywhere, and the long-term opportunity reaches well beyond the state.

Longer term, an optional, privacy-preserving way for users to support one another could deepen results across all four programs. Because shared content brings new safety duties, this community layer is gated: it moves forward only with dedicated funding, legal review, a Trust and Safety plan, and Board approval. Each 2027 town hall asks users whether they want it and what would make it feel safe.

Partner with us

Grants and gifts of any size keep the apps free, and larger investments expand what each program can deliver.

Investment	What it makes possible
Contract development hours	Faster, steadier releases and fixes after launch
Paid accessibility testing	Stipends so disabled testers are paid for their expertise
Lived-experience focus groups	Stipends for people in recovery, self-advocates, and families who help design the apps
Evaluation tools and partner	Survey tools in 2027 and an independent evaluation partner by 2029
Outreach and workshops	Self-advocacy workshops, recovery-center outreach, partner training, and the East Metro pilot

We also welcome in-kind help, such as pro bono legal or accounting review, accessibility expertise, and design.

Contact: Sam, Executive Director · sam@appsforchange.org · appsforchange.org

Sources

1. Minnesota House Research Department, “Overview of Medicaid Home- and Community-Based Waiver Services,” September 2025. lrl.mn.gov
2. KFF State Health Facts, “Individuals Ages 12 or Older with Any Substance Use Disorder in the Past Year,” SAMHSA NSDUH 2022-2023, Minnesota. kff.org
3. Minnesota Department of Health, “Drug Overdose Deaths by County (2016-2025).” health.state.mn.us
4. Gallup, “U.S. Depression Rate Remains Historically High,” September 9, 2025. news.gallup.com